BOTÂNORA

N° 10



Yerba Mate

From chimarrão to tereré and toasted mate

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BOTÂNORA · GUIDE N° 10

Yerba Mate

Chimarrão, tereré and mate tea done right

Yerba mate is the drink that unites southern Brazil, Paraguay, Argentina and Uruguay. It was born with the Guarani peoples, crossed colonial history and became a ritual of friendship: one gourd passed hand to hand, with water always at the same temperature.

This guide tells that story, explains the plant and its processing, teaches you to choose the yerba, cure the gourd and set up a chimarrão that lasts, introduces tereré and toasted mate and ends with eighteen recipes, from chipa to mate cocido, and a four-week path to learning to love chimarrão.



01

Choose the right yerba

Chimarrão, tereré and toasted tea use different yerbas.

02

Cure the gourd

A one-time step that changes the flavour.

03

Mind the water

Never boiling: 70 to 75 °C.

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CHAPTER I

The herb

History, plant and process

Before it was chimarrão, yerba mate was food, currency and the economic engine of whole regions. Understanding the plant and the process explains why each yerba tastes so different.

01 A drink with history

02 The plant and the process

03 Types of yerba



CHAPTER I

A drink with history

The Guarani consumed the leaves of *caá* long before Europeans arrived: chewed, infused and in ceremonies. They drank from a gourd with a cane straw filtered with fibres, the origin of the cuia and the bomba.

In the 17th and 18th centuries, the Jesuit missions learned to cultivate the plant, which until then was only gathered in the forest. Yerba became an export product across the River Plate region and the Pacific coast.

In 19th-century Brazil, the so-called yerba mate cycle drove the economy of Paraná and Santa Catarina, and in Mato Grosso do Sul large companies worked the native groves. In Rio Grande do Sul, chimarrão became a symbol of identity and hospitality.

One name, many forms

DRINK	WHERE	HOW
Chimarrão	Southern Brazil	Large gourd, fine green yerba, hot water
Mate	Argentina and Uruguay	Smaller gourd, yerba with more stem, sometimes sweetened
Tereré	Paraguay, Mato Grosso do Sul, western Paraná	Guampa, coarse yerba, iced water or juice
Mate tea	South-east and all Brazil	Toasted leaves, steeped or iced

Whoever offers the gourd offers time.

CHAPTER I

The plant and the process

Ilex paraguariensis is a tree native to the southern Atlantic Forest, a relative of holly. It grows in the shade of araucaria pines or in full-sun plantations.

1. **Harvest.** Branches and leaves are cut every 18 to 24 months, usually in winter, when the plant is dormant.
2. **Sapeco.** The leaves pass quickly through fire (seconds). This stops oxidation and keeps the green colour, like steaming does for green tea.
3. **Drying.** In belt dryers or the traditional barbaquá, over indirect fire, until brittle.
4. **Cancheamento.** Coarse crushing of the dried leaves and stems.
5. **Ageing (estacionamiento).** In Brazil, yerba usually reaches the market green and fresh. In Argentina and Uruguay it rests for months or years, turning yellowish and milder.
6. **Milling and blending.** Sets the grind and the proportion of leaf, stem and dust.

What is in the gourd

Yerba mate contains caffeine (with theobromine, the same as in cacao), polyphenols such as chlorogenic acid and saponins, responsible for the foam and the characteristic bitterness. A chimarrão session can add up to 80 to 150 mg of caffeine, depending on the amount of yerba and the number of rounds.

CHAPTER I

Types of yerba

The grind and the ageing define the use. Use the right yerba for each preparation.

TYPE	APPEARANCE	FLAVOUR	USE
Traditional chimarrão	bright green, fine grind, with dust	grassy, intense, marked bitterness	chimarrão
Native or shade-grown	darker green	milder and sweeter	beginner chimarrão
Coarse ground	larger pieces, little dust	clean, lasts longer	chimarrão and tereré
Tereré	coarse grind, sometimes with herbs	fresh, less bitter	iced water
Argentine "con palo"	yellowish, with stems	mild, woody	Argentine mate
Uruguayan "pura hoja"	fine powder, no stems	strong, full-bodied	Uruguayan mate
Toasted mate tea	brown chopped leaves	roasted, caramel, mild	infusions, iced drinks, lattes

How to store

Tightly closed pack, somewhere cool and dark. Brazilian green yerba loses colour and freshness within a few months of opening; choose 500 g to 1 kg packs you will finish in a few weeks. Do not keep it in the fridge: moisture cakes the yerba.

> BOTÂNORA TIP
> Very yellow yerba or one smelling of stale hay is a sign of expired or badly stored yerba, not of aged yerba.

CHAPTER II

The chimarrão

Gourd, bombilla and water

A good chimarrão lasts dozens of rounds without going flat. The secret is a cured gourd, a set-up with the yerba tilted and water that never boils.

01 The tools and curing

02 Setting up step by step

03 Water, mistakes and etiquette



CHAPTER II

The tools and curing

Gourd

Calabash

Made from the dried calabash fruit. Choose one without cracks, with a thick shell and a mouth the size of your hand.

Bombilla

Stainless steel or nickel silver

Prefer stainless steel, easier to clean. A bulb with fine holes (or a spring) holds back the dust.

Thermos

1 L

With a pouring spout: it controls the stream and holds the temperature for hours.

Curing a new gourd

1. Scrape the loose film from the inside with a spoon.
2. Fill with used (or fresh) yerba and warm water. Leave 24 h.
3. Empty, scrape again and repeat for 2 to 3 days.
4. Rinse without detergent and dry mouth-down somewhere airy and out of the sun.

Curing removes the calabash taste and seals the pores. Afterwards, the gourd never sees soap: only hot water, and dry it thoroughly before storing so it does not go mouldy.

> **HYGIENE**
> Dark patches with a musty smell mean the gourd should be thrown out. Ceramic, treated wood or stainless gourds are easy-to-clean alternatives.

CHAPTER II

Setting up step by step

The gaúcho method, which makes the chimarrão last.

1. **Fill two thirds** of the gourd with yerba.
2. **Cover with your hand and turn** the gourd upside down, shaking. The fine dust rises to your palm: discard it.
3. **Tilt the gourd** to 45 degrees and shake gently, so the yerba forms a slope on one side and leaves an empty space on the other.
4. **Wet the empty space with lukewarm water**, not hot (around 40 °C), only in the hollow. Wait for the yerba to absorb it: this protects the rest from the heat.
5. **Cover the top of the bombilla with your thumb** and push it into the wet space, to the bottom, against the gourd wall. Do not move it again.
6. **Pour the water at 70–75 °C** always at the same spot, next to the bombilla, without wetting the top of the yerba.
7. **The first mate belongs to the cebador.** It is the most bitter and dusty; whoever prepares it drinks it and only then passes it on.

> BOTÂNORA TIP
> When the chimarrão goes "washed" (flat), do not change it all: pull the dry yerba from the top towards the bombilla and carry on. It gives a few more rounds.

CHAPTER II

Water, mistakes and etiquette

The temperature

Between 70 and 75 °C. The water starts forming small bubbles on the bottom of the kettle, "singing", and it is time to turn it off. Boiling water burns the yerba, makes the chimarrão bitter and goes flat faster. Moreover, the International Agency for Research on Cancer (IARC) classifies very hot drinks, above 65 °C when drunk, as probably carcinogenic to the oesophagus: let the water settle and drink unhurriedly.

MISTAKE	RESULT	FIX
Boiling water	bitter, goes flat fast	70–75 °C
Moving the bombilla	clogs and lets dust through	never move it once set
Wetting the top of the yerba	flat in a few rounds	water always beside the bombilla
Stale yerba	dull, tastes of hay	fresh, sealed pack

Circle etiquette

- The cebador prepares, serves each round and drinks the first.
- Drink all the water until the gourd "snores" and hand it back to the cebador, never to your neighbour.
- Do not touch the bombilla or complain that it is hot: it belongs to everyone.
- "Thank you" means "no more for me". Say it only when you want to leave the circle.
- The circle follows the order, usually anticlockwise.

CHAPTER III

Tereré and mate tea

The cold yerba and the toasted yerba

In the heat of Paraguay and Mato Grosso do Sul, yerba goes with iced water. In Rio de Janeiro and the south-east, toasted leaves become the beach mate tea. They are two gateways for anyone who finds chimarrão too bitter.

01 Tereré

02 Toasted mate tea



CHAPTER III

Tereré

Recognised by UNESCO in 2020 as Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity, in its traditional Paraguayan practices.

1. **Guampa:** a cup of horn, wood or metal, larger than a gourd.
2. **Coarse yerba**, made for tereré, that does not clog the bombilla in the cold.
3. **Ice-cold water** in an insulated jug with ice. It can carry blended herbs (the *yuyos*) or fruit juice.
4. **Set up like chimarrão** (tilted, bombilla in the hollow) and serve round after round.

Yuyos: the herbs of tereré

HERB	TRADITIONAL USE
Mint	refreshing
Lemongrass	citrus flavour and calming
Boldo	digestion (see cautions in the Backyard Herbs guide)
Cocú (Allophylus edulis)	freshness, widely used in Paraguay

> **BOTÂNORA TIP**
> Tereré with juice is a great gateway: lime, orange, pineapple or passion fruit soften the bitterness.

CHAPTER III

Toasted mate tea

Yerba mate leaves are roasted, which reduces bitterness and brings notes of caramel and bread.

PREPARATION	AMOUNT	WATER	TIME
Hot cup	1 tbsp (≈ 2 g)	250 ml at 90 °C	4–5 min
Iced jug	4 tbsp	500 ml boiling + 500 ml iced	5 min
Cold brew	20 g	1 L cold	6–8 h
Latte base	2 tbsp	100 ml at 90 °C	5 min

The beach mate

On Rio's beaches, iced mate with lime is served from big drums by walking vendors, almost always with polvilho biscuits. The home version (recipe 6) has less sugar and freshly squeezed lime.

Yerba, chimarrão or mate tea: which has more caffeine?

Per cup, toasted mate tea has less caffeine than drip coffee. Chimarrão feels "stronger" because it uses much more yerba and stretches over many rounds: over a whole session, it can exceed two cups of coffee.

> **CAFFEINE**
> Pregnant people, children and those sensitive to caffeine should moderate mate in any form.

CHAPTER IV

Eighteen recipes

From the gourd to the glass

Recipes that respect tradition and others that take yerba to the café, the summer and dessert. Measures: tsp ≈ 5 ml, tbsp ≈ 15 ml.

01 Mint Chimarrão
02 Mate with Orange Peel
03 Pineapple Tereré
04 Lemongrass Tereré
05 Chimarrão with Fennel
06 Iced Mate with Lemon
07 Mate with Ginger and Honey
08 Yerba Mate Cold Brew
09 Mate Tonic
10 Winter Spiced Mate
11 Mate Shake
12 Mate & Dulce de Leche Ice Cream



N° 01

Mint Chimarrão

The usual gourd, fresher.

GOURD · CAFFEINATED

⅔ of the gourd	chimarrão yerba
4 leaves	fresh mint
at 70–75 °C	water

Set up the gourd as usual and tuck the mint leaves beside the bombilla.

N° 02

Mate with Orange Peel

Citrusy and round.

GOURD · CAFFEINATED

⅔ of the gourd	yerba mate
1 strip	dried orange peel
at 75 °C	water

Mix the chopped peel into the yerba before setting up.

N° 03

Pineapple Tereré

Fruit juice instead of water.

GUAMPA · CAFFEINATED

⅔ of the guampa	tereré yerba
500 ml	ice-cold pineapple and mint juice

Pour the iced juice round after round, as you would water.

N° 04

Lemongrass Tereré

The most common "yuyo" in Paraguay.

GUAMPA · CAFFEINATED

⅔ of the guampa	tereré yerba
500 ml	iced water blended with lemongrass and strained

Blend the water with 3 lemongrass leaves, strain and chill. Serve in the guampa.

N° 05

Chimarrão with Fennel

An aniseed touch that softens the bitterness.

GOURD · CAFFEINATED

⅔ of the gourd	chimarrão yerba
1 tsp	fennel seeds
at 70–75 °C	water

Mix the fennel into the yerba before setting up the gourd.

N° 06

Iced Mate with Lemon

The beach drink, made at home.

1 L · CAFFEINATED

4 tbsp	toasted mate tea
500 ml	boiling water
500 ml	iced water
2	limes (juice)
60 ml	simple syrup

Steep 5 min, strain, sweeten and top up with iced water and lime.

N° 07

Mate with Ginger and Honey

For cold days and tired throats.

1 CUP · CAFFEINATED

1 tbsp	toasted mate tea
3 slices	ginger
250 ml	water
1 tsp	honey

Simmer the ginger 5 min, turn off, add the mate for 4 min. Strain and sweeten once warm.

N° 08

Yerba Mate Cold Brew

Green, grassy and not bitter.

1 L · CAFFEINATED

25 g	yerba mate
1 L	cold filtered water

Fridge for 4 h. Strain through a paper filter to remove the dust.

N° 09

Mate Tonic

Mate cold brew and tonic.

1 GLASS · CAFFEINATED

100 ml	yerba mate cold brew
150 ml	tonic water
1 wheel	orange

Glass with ice, mate, tonic poured slowly and orange.

N° 10

Winter Spiced Mate

Cinnamon, clove and orange.

2 CUPS · CAFFEINATED

2 tbsp	toasted mate tea
1	cinnamon stick
3	cloves
500 ml	water

Simmer the spices 5 min, turn off, add the mate for 5 min.

N° 11

Mate Shake

Mate, banana and cacao shake.

1 GLASS · CAFFEINATED

150 ml	strong cold toasted mate
1	frozen banana
1 tbsp	cocoa powder
100 ml	milk

Blend everything for 40 s.

N° 12

Mate & Dulce de Leche Ice Cream

No-churn, with toasted mate flavour.

≈ 700 ML

100 ml	very strong toasted mate, cold
200 g	dulce de leche
400 ml	chilled double cream

Mix the mate into the dulce de leche. Whip the cream to stiff peaks, fold in and freeze 6 h.

13 Mate Cocido with Milk

Boiled mate from Argentina and Paraguay, breakfast for many families.

Hot · 8 min · 2 mugs · Caffeinated · With milk · Easy

INGREDIENTS

2 tbsp	yerba mate
1 tbsp	sugar
250 ml	water
250 ml	milk

Finish. With cheese bread or chipa (recipe 16).

METHOD

1. Lightly caramelise the sugar with the yerba in a small pan, stirring, for 1 min.
2. Add the water and simmer 2 min.
3. Add the milk, heat without boiling and strain.

BARISTA TIP Caramelising the yerba with sugar is the secret of the traditional version: it softens the bitterness.

14 Passion Fruit & Mint Tereré

The most requested juice version in Mato Grosso do Sul.

Iced · 10 min · guampa + 1 L · Caffeinated · Easy

INGREDIENTS

⅔ of the guampa	tereré yerba
2	passion fruits (pulp)
1 L	iced water
8 leaves	mint
2 tbsp	sugar (optional)

METHOD

1. Blend the pulp with the water, mint and sugar and strain.
2. Pour into an insulated jug with plenty of ice.
3. Set up the guampa and pour the juice round after round.

BARISTA TIP Very sweet juice clogs the bombilla and sticks to the yerba: go light on sugar.

15 Mate & Orange Cake

An afternoon cake, fragrant and moist.

Hot · 1 h · 1 medium tin · Caffeinated · Easy

INGREDIENTS

200 ml	strong toasted mate (3 tbsp in 200 ml)
3	eggs
200 g	sugar
120 ml	oil
240 g	plain flour
1 tbsp	baking powder
1	orange zest and juice

METHOD

1. Beat the eggs, sugar and oil until pale.
2. Add the cold mate, zest and flour. Finally the baking powder.
3. Bake at 180 °C for 40 min.
4. While warm, drizzle with orange juice and 2 tbsp sugar.

BARISTA TIP Toasted mate has caramel notes that pair with orange and cinnamon.

16 Chipa

Paraguayan cheese bread, tereré's partner.

Hot · 40 min · ≈ 20 pieces · Caffeine-free · With milk · Intermediate

INGREDIENTS

500 g	sweet tapioca starch
200 g	grated semi-hard cheese
100 g	butter
2	eggs
100 ml	milk
1 tsp	salt and 1 tsp fennel seed

METHOD

1. Rub the starch and butter together into crumbs.
2. Add the cheese, eggs, salt and fennel. Add the milk gradually until the dough is smooth and mouldable.
3. Shape into rings or balls.
4. Bake at 200 °C for 20 to 25 min, until golden underneath.

BARISTA TIP Unlike Brazilian pão de queijo, chipa dough is not scalded: it is firmer and keeps longer.

17 Mate Syrup

For iced drinks, mocktails and desserts.

Hot · 15 min · 1 bottle · 300 ml · Caffeinated · Easy

INGREDIENTS

4 tbsp	toasted mate tea
250 ml	boiling water
200 g	brown sugar or panela

METHOD

1. Steep the mate for 8 min and strain well.
2. Dissolve the sugar in the tea and simmer 3 min.
3. Cool and bottle.

BARISTA TIP A spoonful in sparkling water with lime makes a mate soda. Keeps 3 weeks in the fridge.

18 Mate & White Chocolate Cookies

Olive-green, crisp outside.

Hot · 25 min + 30 min · ≈ 18 cookies · Caffeinated · With milk · Easy

INGREDIENTS

115 g	butter
150 g	brown sugar
1	egg
200 g	plain flour
1 tbsp	finely ground, sifted yerba mate
½ tsp	baking soda
100 g	chopped white chocolate

METHOD

1. Beat the butter and sugar, add the egg.
2. Mix in the flour, mate and soda; then the chocolate.
3. Chill 30 min. Spaced balls, 180 °C for 11 min.

BARISTA TIP Grind the yerba in a blender and sift: only the fine powder goes in the dough.

MORE RECIPES AND QUESTIONS

Gourds and bombillas

How to choose gear that will last for years.

GOURD	PROS	CONS
Calabash	Traditional, flavour improves with use	Needs curing and care against mould
Wood (palo santo, algarrobo)	Its own aroma, beautiful	Can crack; also needs curing
Ceramic or glass	Easy hygiene, no curing, no taste	Gets hot; can break
Double-wall steel	Tough, insulated, travel-friendly	Less traditional

BOMBILLA	FOR	NOTE
Holed bulb	medium-grind chimarrão	Classic, easy to clean
Spring	fine, dusty yerba	Filters better; take apart to wash
Wide flat bulb	tereré and coarse yerba	Does not clog in the cold

BOTÂNORA TIP

Once a week, boil the steel bombilla for 5 minutes or soak it in water with baking soda: it removes the residue that turns bitter.

MORE RECIPES AND QUESTIONS

Frequently asked questions

MY CHIMARRÃO IS TOO BITTER. WHAT CAN I DO?

Lower the temperature to 70 °C, use a mild or native yerba, fill only half the gourd and do not leave water sitting on the yerba. If it is still strong, start with toasted mate tea or tereré with juice.

HOW MANY GOURDS A DAY IS OK?

It depends on your caffeine sensitivity. One session can exceed 100 mg. Add it to your coffee and other teas and avoid it in the 6 hours before bed if your sleep is sensitive.

CAN I SWEETEN IT?

In southern Brazil chimarrão is bitter by tradition. In Argentina many people sweeten it. If you do, keep a gourd just for that: sugar stays in the calabash.

HOW LONG DOES OPENED YERBA LAST?

Brazilian green yerba loses freshness within 1 to 2 months of opening. Close the pack tightly or move it to an opaque container.

IS SHARING THE BOMBILLA SAFE?

The circle is part of the tradition, but a shared bombilla passes on colds and other infections. When someone is unwell, everyone gets their own gourd.

WHY DOES THE YERBA GO FLAT SO FAST?

Water too hot, water on top of the yerba or a moved bombilla. Follow the tilted set-up in chapter II and always pour in the same spot.

MORE RECIPES AND QUESTIONS

From bitter to habit

A four-week path for anyone who has never had chimarrão and wants to learn to enjoy it.

WEEK	WHAT TO DRINK	WHY
1	Toasted mate with orange and honey	Same background taste, no bitterness
2	Tereré with fruit juice	First contact with green yerba, cold and sweet
3	Tereré with water and mint	The real taste of yerba, still refreshing
4	Chimarrão with mild yerba, at 70 °C, half a gourd	Now the palate is ready

YERBA I LIKED MOST

IDEAL TEMPERATURE AND AMOUNT

BITTERNESS ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

WANT TO REPEAT ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

The first chimarrão is strange. By the tenth, you will miss it.



Thank you for brewing with us

The Botânora collection has ten guides, each devoted to one way of living with tea. Keep exploring:

01 Signature Infusions
02 The Tea Atlas
03 The Night Ritual
04 Focus & Energy
05 Iced & Cold Brew
06 Matcha at Home
07 Backyard Herbs
08 Crafting Blends
09 Tea & Table

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